

ACTIVITY 1 — FACILITATOR GUIDE**Role Play: Foundations of Selling**

TYPE	DURATION	MAPS TO	TOPIC
Role Play	1 hour	LU1	LU1 — Foundations of Selling

Purpose of this activity

By the end of this activity learners will be able to apply mindset, empathy, buyer psychology and discovery questioning in a live sales call (LU1).

What learners produce

A completed Role-Play Observer Scorecard citing the exact line used for the opening mindset, one genuine Gap Question, one named principle of influence, and the buying signal that led to the close.

Materials required

- Learner Worksheet (one per learner)
- Checklist (one per group)
- Flipchart or A3 sheet and markers
- The course slides for the scenario and framework
- Internet access where the activity calls for live research

Set-up

Groups of exactly 3 so every role is played. Distribute one worksheet per learner and one checklist per group. Each Learning Unit carries one role play, and each uses a different, self-contained sales scenario — brief the situation and the roles fully before starting, since learners are not carrying a story across from the previous activity.

Scenario / briefing material

Jessica is a sales rep for CloudFlow, a cloud-based project-management platform. John is a project manager at Sunrise Builders, a mid-sized construction firm in Singapore, where every job is tracked on shared spreadsheets. Since the team grew from 8 to 19, two handover deadlines have slipped because updates never reached the right person — and John's director asked him about it in front of the team.

This is Jessica's first real conversation with John. Her goal for the call is NOT to sell software: it is to earn enough trust to run a genuine discovery conversation. John has sat through several demos before, bought a tool two years ago that nobody adopted, and is quietly testing whether this rep is any different.

The scene runs from the opening minute — mindset, rapport, permission to ask — through discovery using Why-Why-Why and Gap questions, into a solution shaped by what John actually said, addressing his fear of another failed rollout, and closing on one concrete next step.

Roles

Assign one role per participant:

- **Jessica — Sales Rep, CloudFlow — Goal:** *Earn trust and uncover John's real project-tracking pain before proposing anything.* Trained to lead with permission-based discovery, not a features list. She must resist pitching for the first five minutes, however tempting John's opening complaint makes it.
- **John — Project Manager, Sunrise Builders — Goal:** *Decide whether this rep genuinely understands construction chaos, or is just selling.* Burned by a tool his team never adopted. He will open with a surface complaint ('we just need better reminders') that is NOT the real problem — the real problem is that he is personally accountable for information he cannot see.
- **Observer / Coach — Goal:** *Score the conversation against the Foundations checklist and give usable feedback.* Watches for mindset language, affect labelling, genuine Gap questions, named principles of influence, and the moment hesitation turns into a buying signal. Quotes exact lines in the debrief — never general impressions.

How to run it — step by step

#	Instruction to learners	Facilitator note
1	Assign the three roles. One learner plays Jessica (sales rep, CloudFlow project-management SaaS), one plays John (buyer, project manager at Sunrise Builders, a mid-sized construction firm). Everyone else is Observer/Coach for this round, working from the scorecard in the worksheet.	Watch for Jessica reverting to a feature dump the instant John hesitates — redirect her back to a question, not a longer pitch.
2	Round 1 — open honestly, not with a script. Jessica opens by stating her real intent before asking anything — something like 'before we get into details, I want to make sure I understand your needs so we focus on what actually helps you.' John responds with his real, specific frustration (missed deadlines, spreadsheets not scaling). The Observer notes whether Jessica's opener sounded human or scripted.	The most common miss is jumping from the opener straight to presenting a solution — insist the discovery ladder (Gap Question, then Why-Why-Why) actually happens on screen.
3	Round 2 — climb the discovery ladder. Jessica asks a genuine Gap Question ('what specifically isn't working with the current system?'), then follows John's answer with at least one Why-Why-Why chain to get from a surface complaint ('spreadsheets aren't cutting it') down to the real cause ('the team outgrew that method as	If a pair finishes early, re-run the close with John raising a harder, more specific objection about budget approval.

	we scaled'). John should only reveal the deeper cause once actually asked — don't let Jessica skip straight to pitching.	
4	Round 3 — present a solution tied to what John just said. Jessica presents CloudFlow using the Power of Words (specific, concrete benefits framed around John's stated pain, e.g. 'you'll never chase a status update again') and offers the Illusion of Choice: a small pilot with one team versus a full rollout — never a single take-it-or-leave-it option.	
5	Round 4 — handle the hesitation and reduce fear. John raises a genuine concern about the transition (time, disruption to a busy team). Jessica reduces that fear with something concrete — a trial period, free onboarding support, a guarantee — not just verbal reassurance ('trust me, it'll be fine').	
6	Close on a specific, dated next step. Jessica confirms a concrete onboarding date rather than a vague 'let's stay in touch.' John should be able to say the date back in his own words before the round ends.	
7	Observer completes the scorecard. Using the worksheet, the Observer writes down the exact line used for the mindset opener, the Gap Question, the principle of influence in play (name it: reciprocity, social proof, authority, liking, scarcity, unity, or commitment/consistency), and the buying signal that triggered the close.	

Suggested timing

Minutes	Phase
5 min	Brief the scenario and assign the three roles
10 min	Round 1 — Open with mindset, not a pitch
15 min	Round 2 — Run the discovery ladder (Gap Questions, Why-Why-Why)
10 min	Round 3 — Present the solution using influence and the illusion of choice
10 min	Round 4 — Build trust, reduce fear, and close on a dated next step
10 min	Observer scores the call and runs the debrief

Total: 60 minutes

Discussion & decision prompts

1. Where did Jessica's mindset actually show up in her word choice — and where did it slip into pitching?

2. Which questions were genuine Gap Questions, and which were closed questions dressed up as open ones?
3. Did Jessica ever name John's emotion out loud (affect labelling)? What changed in the conversation right after — or what was missed by skipping it?
4. Which of Cialdini's principles did Jessica use, deliberately or not — and did it land as genuinely helpful or as manipulation?
5. At what exact line did John's hesitation become a buying signal rather than a polite brush-off?
6. John's stated problem was 'better reminders'. What was the real problem underneath, and which question surfaced it?

Debrief

Bring the class back together and draw out the learning:

- Ask two or three groups to show what they produced, not just what they concluded.
- Ask what surprised them — the gap between what they assumed and what they found.
- Link the activity explicitly back to LU1 — Foundations of Selling.

Reflection questions:

- What surprised you about how quickly trust built once Jessica asked permission to ask questions?
- Did the two-option close (pilot vs full rollout) feel empowering to the buyer, or like pressure in disguise?
- Which single question from the discovery phase would you steal for your own next sales call?

Facilitator notes — what to watch for

- Watch for Jessica reverting to a feature dump the instant John hesitates — redirect her back to a question, not a longer pitch.
- The most common miss is jumping from the opener straight to presenting a solution — insist the discovery ladder (Gap Question, then Why-Why-Why) actually happens on screen.
- If a pair finishes early, re-run the close with John raising a harder, more specific objection about budget approval.

Success criterion

The observer can quote at least one specific mindset moment, one genuine Gap Question, one attempt at naming John's emotion, one named principle of influence, and one real buying signal — with the exact line cited, not a general impression.

Course link

This activity builds LU1 — Foundations of Selling. All four role plays are in-class activities that practise a one-to-one sales conversation built on the course's discovery, closing and objection-handling techniques.